

PELICAN BAY POLICE DEPARTMENT
HOMICIDE DIVISION — EIGHTH DISTRICT
715 South Broad Avenue, New Orleans, LA 70119
(504) 658-6080

DETECTIVE'S INITIAL INVESTIGATION REPORT

Case No.: PBPB-2026-034532 | Document No.: 02

Reporting Detective: Det. Yvette Landry, Badge #1887

Assignment: Homicide Unit — Lead Investigator

Date of Report: October 4, 2025

Incident Date/Time: October 4, 2025 — approx. 2:25 AM (estimated TOD)

Case Classification: Homicide — Blunt Force Trauma

Location: Alley Rear of 712 Bourbon Street, New Orleans, LA 70116

Victim: DAMARI THORNTON, M/B, DOB: 03/14/1991 (Age 34)

I. NOTIFICATION AND RESPONSE

On October 4, 2025, at 3:05 AM, this detective was notified by PBPB Communications of a deceased male discovered in the alley to the rear of 712 Bourbon Street. The call was initially routed through the Eighth District. This detective departed residence at 3:14 AM and arrived on scene at 3:35 AM. Upon arrival, this detective was briefed by Officer Aimee Beaulieu (#2241), first responding officer.

II. SCENE WALKTHROUGH AND OBSERVATIONS

After being briefed and donning protective gear, this detective conducted a controlled walkthrough of the scene under the supervision of Officer Beaulieu who had preserved both inner and outer perimeters. The following observations were made:

1. The decedent, later confirmed as DAMARI THORNTON, was lying prone approximately 28 feet from the Bourbon Street mouth of the alley, head oriented east. A large pool of partially congealed blood extended from beneath the head to approximately 14 inches east of the body.
2. A partial shoe impression in blood was visible approximately 6 inches from the victim's right ribcage. Tread pattern was visible to the naked eye and appeared consistent with a flat, waffle-pattern athletic shoe.
3. The victim's wallet was visible in his right rear pocket and appeared intact. His cellular phone (iPhone, dark case) was face-down approximately 3 inches from his left hand. Robbery did not appear to be the motive based on initial observation.
4. No weapon was observed at scene. Wound morphology suggested an instrument with a hard, cylindrical or elongated profile (later confirmed by autopsy to be consistent with a wooden bat).
5. A single overhead light at the north end of the alley was operational; the south fixture was dark. Visibility in the immediate area of the body was limited.

III. INITIAL DIRECTION OF INVESTIGATION

Based on the scene and witness Beaulieu's account, the investigation will pursue four immediate lines of inquiry:

- (a) Identification and location of the three white males observed fleeing south toward Bourbon Street;
- (b) Acquisition of security camera footage from The Rusty Anchor (consent obtained from owner Gerard Olivier) and surrounding businesses;
- (c) Identification of the anonymous female 911 caller;
- (d) Confirmation of victim identity and notification of next of kin.

IV. PRELIMINARY VICTIM IDENTIFICATION

Victim's wallet was retrieved by CSI Tech Fontenot (#4502) and confirmed to contain a Georgia Driver's License in the name of DAMARI KHALIL THORNTON, 1827 Edgewood Ave SE, Atlanta, GA 30329, DOB 03/14/1991. A press credential from the Southern Ledger Online newspaper, expiration 2026, was also present. Cash count: \$142.00. Two credit cards intact. Identification was photographed in situ and re-inserted prior to formal evidence intake.

V. CRIME SCENE UNIT AND CORONER

Crime Scene Unit (CSI Tech Bernard Fontenot #4502 and Tech Yvette Bourgeois #4517) arrived at 3:41 AM and began scene documentation under this detective's direction. Photography, sketching, and evidence collection commenced. The Orleans Parish Coroner's Office was notified at 4:02 AM; Investigator Daryl Whitman responded at 5:21 AM. Body was released to the Coroner at 5:47 AM for transport to the morgue at 2612 Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd.

VI. WITNESS HANDLING

Witness DARNELL WASHINGTON (41) had been retained by Officer Beaulieu and was relocated to a PBPD vehicle for warmth and to await formal interview. Recorded statement was taken at 4:12 AM (see Document 06). Mr. Pierce was cooperative and was released following statement.

Bar owner PHILLIP ARCENEUX (52) responded to the scene at 3:50 AM and consented to a recorded interview taken at 4:45 AM (Document 07). He further consented to camera access pending warrant; warrant was applied for at 7:14 AM and signed by Magistrate Guidry at 9:02 AM.

VII. NEXT STEPS

1. Sub-files to be opened for each of three unidentified fleeing male subjects.
2. Atlanta PD Liaison to be contacted for next-of-kin notification — to be made in person by Atlanta PD at request of this detective, no later than 12:00 PM Oct 4.
3. Subpoena to Verizon for victim phone records.
4. Editor of Southern Ledger Online (per press credential) to be contacted for background on victim's work and recent travel.
5. Coordination with PBPD Robbery/Assault Unit re: any open cases potentially linked to victim's professional work in the French Quarter.

Detective Signature: _____ Det. Yvette Landry #1887

Supervisor Review: Lt. Andre Fontenot, Homicide Unit — 10/04/2025

Report Filed: October 4, 2025 — 10:48 AM